

Disaggregated by sex, the percentage of females engaged in degree/postgraduate education is higher than the corresponding percentage of males.

Table 7.2 : Percentage Pistribution of Population Aged 03 Years and Over by Educational Activity and Age Group, 2024

Age group) (Years)	Population	Percentage						
		Total	Pre school	School education	Undergraduate/ Postgraduate education	Vocational training/ Technical education	Other educational activity	Not studying
Total	21,134,659	100.0	2.3	20.6	1.5	0.6	1.3	73.7
3 - 4	567,979	100.0	42.2	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.1	57.7
5 -14	3,291,719	100.0	7.4	88.4	0.0	0.0	0.7	3.5
15 -18	1,446,661	100.0	0.0	79.4	0.3	1.0	2.3	17.0
19 - 24	1,956,983	100.0	0.0	15.1	10.9	4.2	5.9	63.9
25 and over	13,871,317	100.0	0.0	0.0	0.8	0.2	0.7	98.3

As shown in Table 7.2, the percentage distribution of involvement or not involvement in educational activities during the reference period varies across different age groups. A higher percentage of the population in the 5–14 and 15–18 age groups were engaged in school education. Further, 63.9 percent of the population in the 19–24 age group were not engaged in educational activities, while 98.3 percent of the population aged 25 years and over were not engaged in educational activities during the reference period. In Sri Lanka, the compulsory school age is between 5 and 16 years. However, a possible reason for the relatively lower percentage of 88.4 percent of children aged 5–14 years attending school education observed at the census may be that, by the Census Date (19.12.2024), many children who had completed five years of age were scheduled to be admitted to Grade 1 in the following year (2025).

Engaging in preschool education activities during the reference period

Children aged 3 to 5 years are generally considered to be those receiving pre-school education. However, as children who enroll in pre-school typically continue their attendance until the commencement of formal schooling, this study focuses on children aged 3 to 6 years who are engaged in pre-school education.

Table 7.3 : Children Enrolled in Pre-school Education During the Reference Period by Age, 2024

Age of child	Total Population	Preschool population	Percentage to total population
3 years	276,648	53,785	19.4
4 years	291,331	185,644	63.7
5 years	302,414	235,434	77.9
6 years	312,159	7,243	2.3

According to Table 7.3, most children attending pre-school are aged 4 and 5 years, while children aged 3 and 6 years represent smaller percentage of the preschool population accounting for 19.4 percent and 2.3 percent, respectively.